

Ethnic discrimination

By the end of the 20th century, many of the goals of the civil rights movement (see [here](#)) appeared to have been achieved, in theory at least. The majority of democratic countries had adopted legislation that granted equal rights to all people regardless of ethnicity, generally alongside laws against discrimination on the grounds of ethnicity. But there is still some way to go before civil rights are universally and comprehensively protected. Attitudes are slowly changing, but public and even official observance is lagging behind the law. Even in countries that are officially opposed to ethnic discrimination, old prejudices and suspicions remain entrenched in their institutions, with the effect that the law is not always strictly or fairly enforced. Minority groups are more likely to be stopped and searched, or convicted of crimes, and less likely to have access to the best universities or the best jobs. Immigration laws are often seen as targeted at minority ethnic groups, as are those banning conspicuous or 'provocative' signs of religion, such as the hijab, or headscarf.

